

The First Real Deadline: A Better Question

第一个真实期限：更好的问题

Theme: 求职、职场与职业发展 · New: 45 · Review: 18 · Planned cumulative progress: 45/6, 127

English Story

The better question arrived over **dinner** on the **eighth** of **August**. “Our **deadline** is **overdue**,” Maya said, “and the **renewal** is not the **priority**.” A **delegation** from the **council** had asked **for** a **description** of how the figures were **used**, and the **statistical office** had sent back **something** that was not a **description** at all. The **little office**, the **court date**, and the **great** unfinished film were all in the same report **for** the first time.

The false assumption was simple: that a **punctual** team is a **keen** team. “We **recommend** a different **matter for today**,” Lin said. “**Yesterday** we sewed the same sleeve twice.” The **telescope**, the **chef**, and the **commodity** trader in the same lift all had a theory about the **following month**, and the **march** of dates was the **thrust** of the whole argument.

The **trademark** of the film was its **authenticity**, and **authenticity** was **indicative** of **something** else: they had not foreseen the **extra** work. A **buckle**, a **supplementary** line, and the **twelfth** paragraph had been added after the launch, and the **consequent** delay was now in the report. A **day** after the **following** one, they would **go** back and count the cost again.

The **subsequent** meeting was short. They concluded that the **push for control** had cost them the **enjoyment** of the work, and that the **desirability** of a fast release was a **matter** of the **head**, not of the **house**. “**Immediately**” became “by the **ninth**”, and “we **must**” became “we will”. The **family name** on the **office** door, **for** the moment, meant more to them than the **deadline**.

The **little business** went on with its small tasks. “A **flock** of them is not a plan,” Maya said. “**Something** has to **move**, or nothing will.” She was right, and she was also tired; the better question, in the end, was not when the film would be finished but who would be blamed if it were not. It was **likely** that nobody would thank them, and **likely** that the **following month** would be worse. They were, in a word, tired, and the tiredness was the **extra** cost that nobody had described.

中文翻译

更好的问题在八月八日的晚餐上到来。“我们的期限已经逾期了，”曼雅说，“而续期并不是优先事项。”委员会的一个代表团要求说明这些数字是如何被使用的，而统计办公室回过来的东西根本算不上说明。那间小办公室、法庭的日期，以及那部伟大而未完成的影片，第一次出现在同一份报告里。

那个错误的假设很简单：准时的团队就是热心的团队。“我们今天推荐换个题目，”林伟说，“昨天我们把同一只袖子缝了两遍。”同一部电梯里的望远镜、厨师和商品交易员，都对下个月有一套理论，而日期的行进正是整场争论的推力所在。

这部影片的商标就是它的真实性，而真实性又指示着另一件事：他们没有预见到额外的工作。一个皮带扣、一行补充文字，以及第十二段，都是在发布之后加进去的，而随之而来的延误如今写进了报告。再过一天，他们会回头重新计算代价。

随后的会议很短。他们得出结论：对控制的推动让他们失去了工作的乐趣，而快速发布的合意性是头脑的问题，不是房子的问题。“立即”变成了“在九号之前”，“我们必须”变成了“我们将”。此刻，办公室门上的那个家姓，对他们比期限更重要。

这桩小生意继续着它的小任务。“一群这样的事不是计划，”曼雅说，“总得有什么动起来，否则什么都不会动。”她说得对，她也很累；说到底，更好的问题不是影片何时完成，而是如果完不成，责任会落在谁头上。很可能没有人会感谢他们，而下个月很可能更糟。一句话，他们累了，而这份疲惫是没有人描述过的额外代价。

Core Vocabulary · 核心词汇

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
must mʌst POS: n	n. 必须, 未发酵葡萄汁, 绝对必要的事物; aux. 必须 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a necessary or essential thing; n. grape juice before or during fermentation; s. highly recommended
month mʌnθ POS: n	n. 月; [经] 月 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a time unit of approximately 30 days
today tə'dei POS: n	n. 今天, 当今, 现在; adv. 今天, 当今 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the present time or age; n. the day that includes the present moment (as opposed to yesterday or tomorrow); ...
matter 'mætə POS: n	n. 事件, 物质, 原因, 素材, 实体, 重要; vi. 有关系 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a vaguely specified concern; n. that which has mass and occupies space; n. a problem; n. (used with negation)...
likely 'laikli POS: a	a. 有可能的, 合适的, 前途有望的; adv. 或许, 可能 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. has a good chance of being the case or of coming about; s. expected to become or be; in prospect; s. within...
yesterday 'jestədi POS: n	n. 昨天; adv. 昨天 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the day immediately before today; n. the recent past; r. on the day preceding today; r. in the recent past; o...
date deɪt POS: n	n. 日期, 约会, 枣椰树; vt. 约会, 定日期; vi. 注明日期, 过时 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the specified day of the month; n. a participant in a date; n. a meeting arranged in advance; n. a particular...
used 'ju:st POS: a	a. 使用过的, 二手的, 习惯的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. employed in accomplishing something
march mɑ:tʃ POS: n	n. 三月, 进行, 行军, 步伐, 长途跋涉, 进行曲, 边界; vi. 进军, 前进, 交界; vt. 使行军, 使行进 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the month following February and preceding April; n. the act of marching; walking with regular steps (espec...
push puʃ POS: n	n. 推, 推动, 奋斗, 攻击, 进取心; vt. 推, 推动, 使伸出, 推行, 逼迫, 增加; vi. 推, 推进, 增加, 努力争取 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the act of applying force in order to move something away; n. the force used in pushing; n. an effort to adv...
following 'fɒləuɪŋ POS: n	n. 下列各项, 部下, 追随者; a. 下列的, 其次的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a group of followers or enthusiasts; s. about to be mentioned or specified; s. immediately following in time...
immediately i'mi:diətli POS: adv	adv. 直接地, 立刻, 立即 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: r. without delay or hesitation; with no time intervening; r. near or close by; r. bearing an immediate relation
dinner 'dɪnə POS: n	n. 晚餐, 正餐, 宴会 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the main meal of the day served in the evening or at midday; n. a party of people assembled to have dinner...
extra 'ekstre POS: n	n. 额外的事物, 另外的收费; a. 额外的, 特别的; adv. 额外地, 特别地, 非常地 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an additional edition of a newspaper (usually to report a crisis); n. something additional of the same kind...
August ɔ:'gʌst, 'b:gəst POS: n	n. 八月; a. 威严的, 令人敬畏的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the month following July and preceding September; s. of or befitting a lord; s. profoundly honored
description di'skripʃən POS: n	n. 描述, 说明, 种类; [经] 说明书(物品), 品名种类, 货物名称 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a statement that represents something in words; n. the act of describing something; n. sort or variety
recommend ˌreke'mend POS: vt	vt. 推荐, 介绍, 劝告, 使受欢迎, 托付; [经] 建议, 推荐 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. push for something; v. make attractive or acceptable
conclude kən'klu:d POS: vt	vt. 结束, 作结论, 推断; vi. 结束, 推断 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. bring to a close; v. reach a conclusion after a discussion or deliberation; v. come to a close; v. reach agre...
priority praɪ'brɪti POS: n	n. 优先权, 优先; [计] 优先级 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. preceding in time
subsequent 'sʌbsɪkwənt POS: a	a. 后来的, 接下去的; [经] 后来的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. following in time or order
keen ki:n POS: a	a. 锋利的, 敏锐的, 强烈的, 敏捷的, 热心的, 渴望的; n. 挽歌, 痛哭; v. 唱挽歌, 痛哭 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a funeral lament sung with loud wailing; s. having a sharp cutting edge or point

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telescope 'telɪskəʊp POS: n	n. 望远镜; vi. 叠缩, 嵌进, 缩短; vt. 使叠缩, 使缩短 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a magnifier of images of distant objects; v. crush together or collapse; v. make smaller or shorter
chef ʃef POS: n	n. 厨师 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a professional cook
statistical stə'tɪstɪkl POS: a	a. 统计的, 统计上的, 统计学的; [经] 统计的, 统计学的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. of or relating to statistics
delegation ˌdelɪ'geɪʃən POS: n	n. 代表团, 派遣代表团, 代表的地位(或权力); [经] 派遣, 委任, 委托 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n a group of representatives or delegates; n authorizing subordinates to make certain decisions
deadline 'dedlæn POS: n	n. 最后期限, 截止期限; [经] 截止日期 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the point in time at which something must be completed
commodity kə'mɒdɪti POS: n	n. 农产品, 商品, 有用的物品; [经] 商品, 货物, 日用品 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. articles of commerce
eighth eɪtθ POS: num	num. 第八, 八分之一 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. position eight in a countable series of things; s. coming next after the seventh and just before the ninth...
thrust θrʌst POS: n	n. 插, 戳, 刺, 猛推, 口头攻击, 推力; vt. 插入, 猛推, 刺, 戳, 强加, 延伸; vi. 插, 刺, 戳, 延伸, (用... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. verbal criticism; v. push forcefully; v. press or force; v. force (molten rock) into pre-existing rock
ninth naɪnθ POS: num	num. 第九, 九分之一 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. position nine in a countable series of things; s. coming next after the eighth and just before the tenth in...
flock flɒk POS: n	n. 兽群, 鸟群, 一群人, 大量, 棉束; vi. 成群而行, 聚集; vt. 用棉束填满 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a church congregation guided by a pastor; n. a group of birds; n. a group of sheep or goats; v. move as a cro...
renewal rɪ'nju:əl POS: n	n. 更新, 革新, 复兴, 恢复, 修补, 补充, 继续, 重订, 重申, 续借; [经] 更新, 换新, 重申 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the act of renewing
enjoyment ɪn'dʒɔɪmənt POS: n	n. 享乐, 快乐, 享受; [经] 使用权 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the pleasure felt when having a good time; n. act of receiving pleasure from something
supplementary ˌsʌplɪ'mentəri POS: a	a. 补足的, 补充的, 追加的; [经] 追加的, 补充的, 增补的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. added to complete or make up a deficiency
twelfth twelfθ POS: num	num. 第十二, 十二分之一 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. position 12 in a countable series of things; s. coming next after the eleventh and just before the thirteen...
foresee fɔ:'si: POS: vt	vt. 预见, 预知 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v realize beforehand; v picture to oneself; imagine possible; v act in advance of; deal with ahead of time
sew seʊ POS: vt	vt. 缝纫, 缝合, 缝; vi. 缝纫 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. fasten by sewing; do needlework; v. create (clothes) with cloth
consequent 'kɒnsɪkwənt POS: n	n. 随后发生的事情, 结果; a. 作为结果的, 合乎逻辑的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s following or accompanying as a consequence
trademark 'treɪdmɑ:k POS: n	n. 商标; [法] 商标 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a formally registered symbol identifying the manufacturer or distributor of a product; v. register the trad...
authenticity ˌɔ:θen'tɪsɪti POS: n	n. 可靠性, 真实性; [经] 确实性, 真实性 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. undisputed credibility
indicative ɪn'dɪkətɪv POS: a	a. 指示的, 象征的, 表示...的; [经] 指标的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. relating to the mood of verbs that is used simple in declarative statements; s. (usually followed by 'of')...
buckle 'bʌkl POS: n	n. 皮带扣, 扣子; vt. 扣住, 使弯曲; vi. 扣住, 变弯曲, 屈服 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. fastener that fastens together two ends of a belt or strap; often has loose prong; v. fasten with a buckle...
overdue 'əʊvə'dju: POS: a	a. 过期的, 未兑的, 迟到的, 早就成熟的; [经] 过期未付的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s past due; not paid at the scheduled time
desirability dɪˌzaɪə'bɪlɪti POS: n	n. 值得想望, 可取; [经] 合意性, 可用性 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the quality of being worthy of desiring

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
punctual 'pʌŋktʃuəl POS: a	a. 准时的, 守时的, 点状的, 中肯的; [经] 准时的, 不误期的, 准时 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. acting or arriving or performed exactly at the time appointed